Voting Choice as a Predictor in County Level Sexual Orientation and Gender Motivated Hate Crimes across the United States: A Latent Growth Modeling Approach

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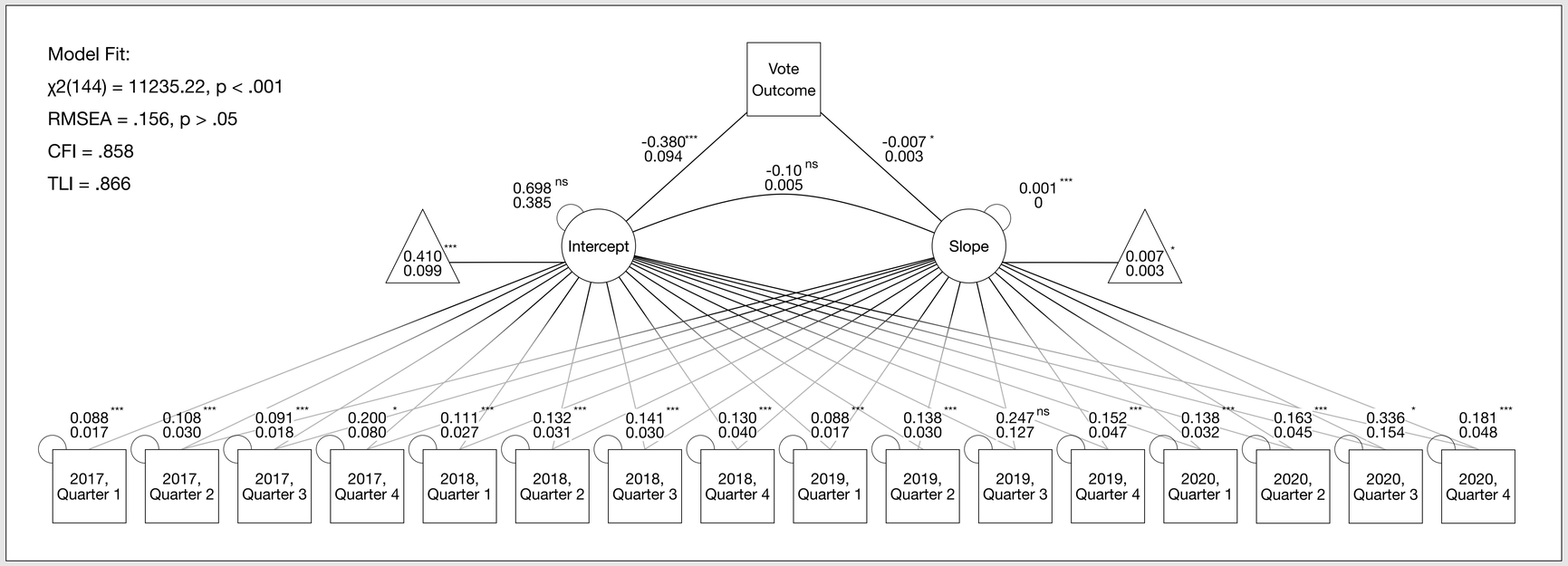
Background & Methods

- LGBTQ-identifying people self-report a victimization rate five times higher than those who do not identify as LGBTQ, as well as reporting nearly six times the amount of violent victimizations [4].
- Following the 2016 election, measures of prejudice for groups targeted by Trump during the campaign trail increased compared to pre-election measures [2].
- We hypothesized lower mean reported incidence in Republican voting counties compared to Democratic voting counties.
- We additionally expected Republican voting counties to have higher initial reported incidents and greater growth trajectories.
- Data for this study were acquired by combining publicly available datasets containing election data from the 2016 presidential election [5] and federal hate crime statistics from 2017 to 2020 [7-10].
- Analysis consisted of the dataset with a Latent Growth Model and a series of Wilcoxon and Mann-Whitney tests.

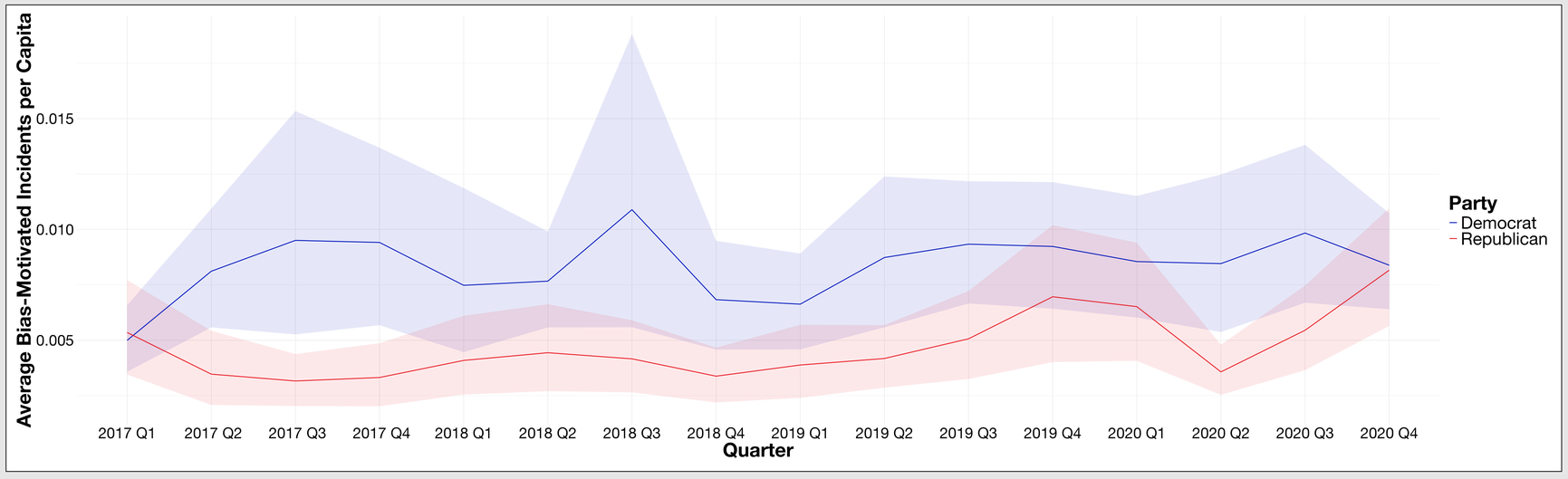
Conclusion

- Contrary to our hypotheses, Democratic voting counties reported higher anti-LGBTQ bias-motivated incidents, had lower initial reported incidents, and slower growth trajectories.
- These results also contradict previous literature that typically aggregate all available bias types motivating bias-motivated incidents [3].
- The unexpected results could stem from differences in population concentration between Democratic and Republican voting counties, as LGBTQ individuals appear to favor living in urban environments over rural areas, which typically vote Democrat [6].
- Population concentration has previously demonstrated effects such that even when controlling for population, the largest racial population groups experience the highest rates of bias-motivated victimization [1].

Results



- Overall, the latent slope of LGBTQ bias-motivated incidents significantly increased at each timepoint with a large amount of variance between counties.
- The latent intercept of LGBTQ bias-motivated incidents was similarly significant, but variance between individual counties was not significant.
- LGBTQ bias incident intercept and slope did not significantly covary.
- Vote outcome had a statistically significant, moderate effect on reported anti-LGBTQ bias-incident intercept, wherein Republican vote was associated with a lower intercept.
- Vote outcome also had a significant but small effect on slope such that reported incidents increased at a slower rate for Republican voting counties.
- Democratic voting counties reported significantly higher average LGBTQ bias-motivated incidents than Republican voting counties for each year of analysis, but the effect for each comparison was small.
- No statistically significant differences in average bias-motivated incidents were found between each year.



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